

Local AI Assistant for Architects

Time-savers you can implement without changing how you design

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Audience: Practicing architects (non-technical)

Goal: Reduce time spent on writing, searching, and coordination

Key idea

The biggest wins come from **text-heavy, repetitive work** (minutes, RFIs, summaries, finding decisions). A local AI assistant supports professional judgement — it doesn't replace it.

Local-first • Private by default • Practical ROI

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This document is intentionally short (about 5 pages) and designed for a quick conversation.

1) What you can do with a local AI assistant

A local AI assistant is best used as a **drafting + search** helper. It can write first drafts, summarize long material, and help you find the right information fast. When it answers questions, it should ideally provide **citations** (quotes + where it found them).

2) All possible use cases (easy → advanced)

Grouped so you can start with quick wins and add more only if useful.

Easy wins (1–3 days to pilot)

- **Meeting → minutes:** turn notes/transcripts into minutes, decisions, and action items.
- **Follow-up emails:** draft clear emails to consultants/clients based on meeting outcomes.
- **RFI / site report drafts:** generate a clean first draft from bullet notes.
- **Client updates:** convert technical notes into a short client-friendly summary.
- **Agenda builder:** generate agendas and pre-reads for coordination meetings.
- **Checklist generator:** produce quick checklists for common tasks (site walk, submittal review).

Medium effort (1–2 weeks to make reliable)

- **"Ask my project" search:** query specs, PDFs, notes, and exported emails with citations.
- **Decision log:** maintain a running log of decisions and assumptions per project.
- **Submittal/RFI summarization:** highlight what changed, what deviates, what needs a decision.
- **Weekly "open loops" report:** compile outstanding items and blockers (by owner).
- **Office standards helper:** answer "how do we usually do this" using your templates/examples.
- **Code/standards helper:** answer from local code PDFs with referenced excerpts.

Tougher (2–6+ weeks, still doable if scoped carefully)

- **Consistency/QA checks (text-based):** detect contradictions across specs, schedules, notes, and prior decisions.
- **Project knowledge library:** find similar past projects/details/decisions across archives (with summaries).
- **Package readiness review:** punchlist before issue (missing decisions, unresolved RFIs, inconsistent notes).
- **Structured extraction:** pull key requirements into tables for review.

Usually hard / risky (set expectations)

- **Reading drawing sheets visually** (plans/sections/callouts) reliably from PDFs.
- **Deep Revit/ArchiCAD automation** (editing models/parameters) without dedicated plugins and testing.
- **Replacing judgement:** AI should support decisions, not make them; citations + review are essential.

3) Best 5 to implement first (and why)

Highest payoff, lowest risk, and useful even if you stop here.

1) Meeting minutes + actions

Why: immediate time savings; fewer missed tasks; better coordination.

How: paste notes/transcript → generate minutes + decisions + action list → send follow-ups.

What's required: a simple minutes template + one place to store meeting notes.

2) "Ask my project" document search (with citations)

Why: reduces time lost searching through PDFs and email threads.

How: keep a Project Vault folder → ask questions → get answers with quoted sources.

What's required: PDFs/notes/email exports + an index so the AI can retrieve the right pages.

3) Draft RFIs / site reports / consultant emails

Why: consistent writing; avoids blank-page drafting.

How: choose a template → provide bullet notes → generate first draft.

What's required: 1–2 examples of your preferred format.

4) Weekly "open loops" summary

Why: keeps projects moving; prevents small items slipping.

How: scan actions + RFIs + notes → one list of outstanding items by owner.

What's required: store actions consistently and tag owners/dates.

5) Code/standards Q&A (local "code librarian")

Why: faster lookups; improves consistency; reduces rework.

How: ask a question → get an answer + cited excerpts from your local code docs.

What's required: code PDFs you use + permission to store locally.

4) What is harder (set expectations)

- Drawing interpretation from PDFs is possible in some cases, but reliability varies widely.
- BIM automation is best treated as a separate project (plugins, testing, change control).
- Quality improves when the AI can cite sources and you have a consistent folder structure.

5) What a basic setup looks like

1. Create one **Project Vault** folder per project (PDFs, notes, key emails/exports).
2. Use consistent subfolders, for example: 01_Admin, 02_Notes, 03_Specs, 04_RFIs, 05_Submittals.
3. Use a local AI tool that can: (a) draft text, and (b) search the vault and cite sources.

6) Questions to tailor this to your workflow

- What tools do you use daily (Revit/ArchiCAD, Bluebeam, Outlook/Gmail, Teams/Zoom, etc.)?
- Where do you lose the most time: searching, writing, coordination, or QA checks?
- Which documents are most common: RFIs, site reports, meeting minutes, specs, submittals?
- Solo or team workflow (shared standards and shared project folders)?
- Any confidentiality constraints (NDAs) that require everything to stay on your machine?
- What would success look like in 2–3 weeks (e.g., save 2 hours/week; fewer missed actions)?